THE GREAT UPRISING OF 1857

Class 8 History | Sample notes

1. CAUSES OF THE UPRISING

- Political: Lord Dalhousie's **Doctrine of Lapse** annexed states whose rulers died without a natural heir; Jhansi and Nagpur were annexed this way.
- Economic: heavy **land revenue** demands pushed many peasants into debt.
- Military: Indian sepoys were **paid less** than British soldiers and had little chance of promotion.
- Immediate cause: the cartridges of the new **Enfield rifle** were rumoured to be greased with cow and pig fat.

2. COURSE OF THE UPRISING

- On 29 March 1857, **Mangal Pandey** attacked his officers at **Barrackpore**.
- On 10 May 1857, sepoys at **Meerut** rose in revolt and marched to Delhi.
- The rebels proclaimed **Bahadur Shah Zafar** as their emperor.
- The British recaptured Delhi in September 1857.

3. LEADERS AND CENTRES

- **Rani Lakshmibai** led the fight at **Jhansi**.
- **Nana Saheb** led the revolt at **Kanpur**.
- **Begum Hazrat Mahal** led the revolt at **Lucknow**.
- **Kunwar Singh** led the revolt in **Bihar**.

4. RESULTS OF THE UPRISING

- The **Government of India Act, 1858** ended the rule of the East India Company.
- Power passed to the **British Crown**; the Governor-General became the **Viceroy**.
- **Queen Victoria's Proclamation** of 1858 promised to respect Indian rulers and religions.
- The army was reorganised because the British wanted to prevent another revolt.
- The uprising led to the end of the Mughal dynasty.

MEMORY TIP: Lapse, land, low pay and the rifle lit the fire.